Adversity has never been a deterrent for Joy Sebastian, co-founder and CEO of Techgentsia Software Technologies. Born into a non-literate fisherfolk family in the coastal village of Pathirapally in Alappuzha district, his parents struggled to educate him. But Joy went on to complete his graduation and then a Master of Computer Applications (MCA) in 1999. The job path took him to an IT startup in Kochi that specialised in internet communication solutions. "My life and career were on track, I was married, drawing a decent salary. But then the company shut shop," recalls Sebastian. That twist of fate came in 2007. "I had a home loan and no money to pay the instalment. I joined a Sharjah-based IT company as a consultant, but that too didn't last long."

It was this second spell of adversity that gave him wings. Joy teamed up with a friend, Tony Thomas, to try peddle their wares on a project basis. Thus was born Techgentsia, with four employees and a small office in Kochi, in 2009. Their first big client was Norway's communications software company Easymeeting. But the weather stayed indeterminate—Easymeeting met its own pocket of turbulence, and Techgentsia felt the jolts. Losses in 2013-14 were severe enough for them to consider winding down operations. "But we knew we had a good product, so we decided to invest in R&D for our video-conferencing tools. After much effort, we developed our flagship brand, Vconsol—a cost-effective, secure and scalable video-conferencing software," says Sebastian.

The COVID-19 pandemic proved to be a turning point. With the world forced into remote work, online classes and virtual meetings, demand for secure video-conferencing solutions skyrocketed. Around the same time, the Prime Minister's Office was looking for an indigenous tool for official use that was efficient and met all the security criteria. In 2020, the Union ministry of electronics and information technology (MeitY) launched an innovation challenge to identify the best solution. Right up Techgentsia's alley—this is what it had been working on for years! And the 'Innovation Challenge for Development of Video Conferencing Solution' award was soon on Joy and Tony's mantelpiece. Their product, Vconsol, was rebranded BharatVC by the Union government and hosted on the National Informatics Centre (NIC) cloud. "The award changed our fortunes. Our product got national attention. We won the prize money of Rs 1 crore," says Sebastian.

Since then, Techgentsia has grown steadily, launching several exclusive products. "We are in expansion mode and developing a proprietary AI-based online video-editing tool," says Sebastian. The company now employs 85 people and manages multiple projects. It provides virtual courtroom solutions to the Kerala, Karnataka, Telangana, Himachal Pradesh and Bombay high courts. Its services are also used by the Indian army, navy, Kerala Police, the Indian Space Research Organisation and several government departments. The company has a roster of global clients, including Oman's health ministry, and their old Norwegian buddy, Easymeeting.

Amidst all this global scaling up, Sebastian has never forgotten the kind of circumstances he had started out from. "We try to recruit candidates from remote areas where opportunities are few," he says. There's poetic justice there somewhere. Silicon comes from sand, and here was a *naadan* beach boy turning it into ethereal gold. ■

FACT SHEET

Name of company
Techgentsia Software Technologies Pvt. Ltd

What they do:
Customise business solutions for internet communication

Founded in: 2009

Annual turnover
Rs 5.25 crore

"SUCCESS DOES NOT COME OVERNIGHT. MY ADVICE TO START-UPS IS TO IDENTIFY A UNIQUE PRODUCT THAT IS IN DEMAND AND FOCUS ON IT"

JOY SEBASTIAN